

READING COMPREHENSION — QUESTION PAPER

Performance and Performativity in Anthropology

PASSAGE

The concept of “performance” within anthropological studies has undergone a significant metamorphosis over the past few decades. Traditionally, anthropological attention to performance was largely confined to overtly ritualistic, ceremonial, or theatrical contexts – events marked as separate from the mundane fabric of daily life. These were often seen as stylized enactments that reinforced social structures, transmitted cultural knowledge, or mediated relationships with the supernatural. While this focus yielded invaluable insights into the symbolic systems and communal functions of such distinct performative genres, it inadvertently created a dichotomy between “performance” as a special, bounded event and “everyday life” as an unscripted, unreflexive domain.

However, influenced by thinkers like Erving Goffman, who explored the dramaturgical aspects of ordinary social interaction, and Victor Turner, whose later work expanded the notion of “social drama” beyond ritual, contemporary anthropology increasingly recognizes that performance is not merely an adjunct to social life but is constitutive of it. This newer perspective emphasizes “performativity” – the idea that social realities, including identities, roles, and even power relations, are actively and continuously constructed through repeated, stylized bodily acts and utterances. Thus, the seemingly trivial interactions of daily life – a particular way of speaking, gesturing, or dressing – become sites of performance, where individuals negotiate, assert, and sometimes subvert social norms and identities.

This expanded understanding does not negate the importance of studying formal performances; rather, it situates them within a broader continuum of performative practices. It allows anthropologists to ask, for instance, how the codes and conventions of a formal ritual might bleed into or be subtly referenced in everyday comportment, or conversely, how everyday performative styles might be amplified or transformed in a ceremonial setting. Furthermore, this approach highlights the agency of individuals. While social structures and cultural scripts provide a framework, they are not deterministic. Individuals interpret, appropriate, and often creatively manipulate these scripts in their daily performances, leading to both the reproduction and potential transformation of social order.

The methodological challenge for anthropologists, then, is to develop ethnographic sensitivities capable of capturing these more pervasive, often subtle, forms of performativity. It requires moving beyond the observation of demarcated “events” to an attentiveness towards the

nuanced ways in which social actors continuously “do” their social worlds into being. This involves a focus on embodiment, discourse, and the contextual interpretation of actions that might otherwise appear insignificant. Ultimately, this shift enriches our understanding of how culture is not just a static set of rules or symbols, but a dynamic, lived process enacted through the myriad performances of its members.

QUESTIONS

Question 1:

The primary purpose of the passage is to:

- A)** examine how anthropological thought on performance was reoriented by absorbing key dramaturgical insights from sociology.
- B)** trace the evolution in the anthropological understanding of performance, from a focus on discrete events to its recognition as a pervasive aspect of social construction.
- C)** argue that recognizing individual agency as a form of performance necessitates a fundamental reorientation of anthropological methodology.
- D)** propose that the concept of 'performativity' reveals the study of formal rituals to be a limited, and ultimately secondary, area of anthropological inquiry.

Question 2:

The passage suggests that a key limitation of the 'traditional' anthropological view of performance was its:

- A)** creation of an artificial dichotomy between stylized, bounded events and the supposedly unreflexive domain of daily life.
- B)** theoretical inability to account for the continuous production and maintenance of social order outside of designated ceremonial contexts.
- C)** failure to recognize the role of individual agency and interpretation even within the seemingly rigid structures of formal rituals.
- D)** inability to explain how cultural knowledge was transmitted effectively through communal, symbolic enactments.

Question 3:

The concept of "performativity," as distinct from "performance," implies that:

- A)** the symbolic codes established in formal, theatrical performances provide the foundational grammar for all everyday performative acts.
- B)** the study of everyday interactions offers a more authentic insight into a culture than the study of its stylized, artificial rituals.

C) social reality is not a pre-existing condition but is continuously brought into being through action.

D) social identity is primarily an unconscious byproduct of repeated bodily habits rather than a consciously constructed presentation of self.

Question 4:

Which of the following can be inferred as a direct challenge to the methodological shift described in the final paragraph?

A) The inherent difficulty of verifying an ethnographer's interpretation of an act as 'performative' against the social actor's own understanding of that act.

B) The practical impossibility of documenting the continuous, pervasive stream of performativity in daily life, as opposed to the discrete, bounded nature of a formal event.

C) The challenge of synthesizing observations of individual, idiosyncratic performances into a coherent model of a culture's broader social structures.

D) The difficulty in distinguishing between performative acts and unreflexive, habitual behaviors.

Atmospheric Aerosol Injection (AAI) and Solar Geoengineering

PASSAGE

Atmospheric aerosol injection (AAI), a form of solar geoengineering, proposes to cool the planet by reflecting a small percentage of incoming sunlight back to space, mimicking the effects of large volcanic eruptions. Proponents suggest AAI could be a relatively inexpensive and rapidly deployable tool to offset some of the warming caused by greenhouse gases, potentially buying time for decarbonization efforts. The primary mechanism involves dispersing fine reflective particles, such as sulfur dioxide, into the stratosphere, where they would remain for a year or two, scattering sunlight. While the theoretical cooling potential is significant, the deployment of AAI is fraught with profound scientific uncertainties, governance dilemmas, and ethical quandaries.

One major concern is the potential for unintended climatic consequences. While AAI might reduce global average temperatures, its effects on regional climate patterns, such as monsoon systems and precipitation, are poorly understood and could be highly disruptive. Altering global atmospheric circulation could lead to droughts in some regions and floods in others, with severe implications for agriculture and water security. Furthermore, AAI does not address the root cause of climate change – greenhouse gas accumulation – and thus would not mitigate ocean acidification, a serious threat to marine ecosystems. There is also the risk of a "termination shock": if AAI were deployed for an extended period and then suddenly stopped, global temperatures could rebound rapidly to levels consistent with the accumulated greenhouse gases, potentially with catastrophic consequences.

The governance of AAI presents another formidable challenge. Unilateral deployment by a single nation or a small group of nations could lead to international tensions and conflicts, especially if perceived negative impacts are attributed to such actions. Establishing a global consensus on whether, when, and how to deploy AAI, along with mechanisms for monitoring, verification, and liability, would be an unprecedented feat of international cooperation. Moreover, the prospect of a "quick fix" like AAI could create a moral hazard, potentially reducing the urgency and political will for the more challenging but essential task of transitioning away from fossil fuels.

Ethical questions also abound. Is it justifiable for the current generation to embark on a planetary-scale intervention with potentially irreversible and inequitably distributed consequences for future generations and diverse ecosystems? Who has the right to make such decisions? The allure of a technological solution to a problem rooted in complex socio-economic systems and consumption patterns can obscure the need for more fundamental societal changes. While research into AAI may be warranted to better understand

its potential and risks, any consideration of deployment must be approached with extreme caution, comprehensive risk assessment, and broad-based, inclusive global deliberation.

QUESTIONS

Question 5:

Which of the following statements best captures the author's primary argument regarding AAI?

- A)** The primary impediments to AAI deployment are not scientific uncertainties but rather the formidable challenges of global governance, moral hazard, and ethical responsibility.
- B)** The potential of AAI to quickly reduce global temperatures is significant, but this benefit is overshadowed by a host of severe and poorly understood risks.
- C)** Given the slow progress on decarbonization, AAI, despite its profound risks, must be retained as a viable last-resort option requiring urgent and comprehensive research.
- D)** The scientific uncertainties surrounding AAI are so profound that any discussion of its deployment is premature and counterproductive to genuine climate action.

Question 6:

All of the following are identified in the passage as potential risks or drawbacks of AAI EXCEPT:

- A)** its ineffectiveness in addressing the non-temperature-related consequences of atmospheric carbon accumulation.
- B)** the possibility of its perceived viability diminishing political motivation for structural economic changes.
- C)** the potential for the injected aerosols to cause direct, large-scale harm to human respiratory health.
- D)** the likelihood of creating geopolitical conflict due to unilateral action.

Question 7:

The author's reference to AAI as a potential "quick fix" (paragraph 3) serves to highlight the concern that:

- A)** it represents a superficial technological response to a problem that is fundamentally rooted in complex socio-economic systems.
- B)** the perceived simplicity of AAI may mask its profound ethical complexities and discourage fundamental societal change.
- C)** it highlights the inherent instability of a solution whose benefits would vanish rapidly upon cessation, creating a permanent dependency.

D) its rapid deployment could trigger immediate and catastrophic climate rebounds without international oversight.

Question 8:

The author's stance on further research into AAI can best be described as:

A) guardedly skeptical, implying that research is unlikely to resolve the fundamental ethical and governance quagmires that are the most significant barriers to deployment.

B) unconditionally supportive, as research is the only way to resolve the current uncertainties and make an informed decision about deployment.

C) conditionally permissive, acknowledging its necessity but insisting it be uncoupled from any immediate consideration of deployment.

D) concerned that even initiating research could create a 'moral hazard' by signaling that a technological solution is forthcoming, thereby undermining decarbonization efforts.

ANSWER KEY

Question	Correct Answer
Question 1	B
Question 2	B
Question 3	C
Question 4	D
Question 5	B
Question 6	C
Question 7	B
Question 8	C